The War, Set to Music

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Armies don't just march — they sing. Listen to eight real recordings from both sides of the U.S.–Mexican War, and hear what the music reveals that the textbook can't.

Music is a source, too

A song is a piece of evidence, just like a letter or a photograph. It was made by someone, for someone, to make them feel something. As you listen to each recording, keep three questions in your head:

You'll hear the American side, the Mexican side, and one strange song that drifted out to sea. Tap each play button, listen, and think about the question under it. Barely any writing until the end.

For the songs that have words, a short "What the words say" note tells you what they're about — and the period song sheet beside each one is the original printed lyric, a primary source you can read straight off the page.

A note on the recordings: these are modern performances and historical records of period songs, gathered for classroom study. Credits are listed at the end.

The American songs

To the United States, this was a war of destiny and adventure. Here is the music the soldiers marched to, pined to, and danced to.

U.S. troops on the march — lithograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

March Away

A patriotic song from the 1840s that calls young men to leave home and march away to war. Songs like this were a recruiting tool — they made going to fight sound thrilling, honorable, and almost romantic.

A Mexican–American War song sheet — lithograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

The Girl I Left Behind Me

One of the most common tunes in the U.S. Army — regiments played it as they marched out of town. Notice that it is not about Mexico, or politics, or glory at all. It is about the sweetheart a soldier leaves behind.

"The Girl I Left Behind Me" sheet music — public domain (Levy Collection, Johns Hopkins).

Green Grow the Lilacs

A sentimental song U.S. soldiers sang during the war. A famous story claims that Mexicans who heard the Americans singing “green grow…” started calling them gringos. It is a great story — but linguists say it is a myth: the word “gringo” is older than the war.

A soldiers’ songster of the era — public domain (Library of Congress).

Jim Along Josie

A lively dance tune that was hugely popular in the 1840s — exactly the kind of thing soldiers played around the campfire to pass long, boring stretches between marches and battles.

“Jim Along Josey” sheet music cover, c. 1840 — a hit song from the blackface minstrel stage. Public domain (source to confirm).

The Mexican songs

Across the line, the same war was an invasion to be survived. Here is the sound of Mexico’s army — and of the people whose homeland became the battlefield.

Mexican soldiers of the war — illustration, public domain (source to confirm).

Marcha Santa Anna

A Mexican military march tied to General Antonio López de Santa Anna, who led Mexico’s armies for much of the war. Every army marches to music; this is the sound Mexican soldiers moved to.

General Antonio López de Santa Anna — portrait, public domain (Library of Congress).

El Degüello (Give Them No Quarter)

A bugle call whose name means roughly “the cutthroat.” Santa Anna famously ordered it played at the Alamo in 1836 to signal that no prisoners would be taken. (The Alamo was part of the Texas Revolution, a decade before this war — but it was the same Santa Anna, and Americans never forgot it.)

The Alamo, San Antonio — illustration, public domain (source to confirm).

Marcha de los Novios

A New Mexican wedding march. The Spanish-speaking communities of New Mexico and the Southwest watched their homeland become first a war zone and then part of the United States. This is their everyday music — not a war song at all.

A New Mexican plaza / Hispano community of the era — illustration, public domain (source to confirm).

Out to sea

Some songs outlived the war and wandered far from the facts. This one became a sailors’ shanty sung across the oceans for a century.

A 19th-century sailing ship — illustration, public domain (source to confirm).

Santa Anna (‘Santianna’)

Sailors turned the war into a sea shanty. Strangely, the song often praises Santa Anna and says he “gained the day” at battles he actually lost. Over time and distance, the facts got scrambled into a good tune.

“Flight of Santa Anna at Cerro Gordo” — lithograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

What the music tells you

Put the songs side by side and patterns jump out. Some are built to stir people up for war. Others are about the human side — missing home, falling in love, killing time in camp. And a couple show history getting bent: a myth about a word, a shanty that gets the battles backwards.

In the examination you won’t write an essay. You’ll match each song to its job, split the stir-you-up songs from the human ones, and then give your take in a sentence or two.